

Upside Down Kingdom 2

Week 1 — 9/29/26

Matthew 5:13–16

Beatitudes
5:3–12

3 Hope Images
5:13–16

Antitheses
5:17–48

Righteous Practices
6:1–20

Parallel Discourses
6:21–7:12

3 Warning Images
7:13–27

REVIEW OF LAST WEEK

The Beattitudes are:

- Jesus's introduction to his sermon
- blessings, not requirements; they are (in context) heard by people who have just been healed and feeling poor in spirit, mournful, etc.
- composed of qualities rejected by the world, and then used as the primary agents of the new (and hence, upside down) kingdom.

PASSAGE OF THE WEEK (NET)

¹¹ Blessed are you when people insult you and persecute you and say all kinds of evil things about you falsely on account of me. ¹² Rejoice and be glad, because your reward is great in heaven, for they persecuted the prophets before you in the same way.

- A { ¹³ You are the salt of the earth. But if salt loses its flavor, how can it be made salty again? It is no longer good for anything except to be thrown out and trampled on by people!
- B { ¹⁴ You are the light of the world. A city located on a hill cannot be hidden.
- C { ¹⁵ People do not light a lamp and put it under a basket but on a lampstand, and it gives light to all in the house. ¹⁶ In the same way, let your light shine before people, so that they can see your good deeds and give honor to your Father in heaven.

¹⁷ Do not think that I have come to abolish the law or the prophets. I have not come to abolish these things but to fulfill them... .

INDIVIDUALS' TRANSLATIONS

R.T. France	Tim Mackie	Willis Barnstone
¹³ You are the salt of the earth. If salt itself becomes tasteless, what else is there to salt it with? It is no good for anything any more except to be thrown out and trampled under people's feet. ¹⁴ You are the light of the world. A town built on top of a hill cannot be hidden. ¹⁵ Nor do people light a lamp only to put it under a bowl; they put it on a lampstand so that it gives light to everyone in the house. ¹⁶ In the same way your light must shine in front of other people, so that they can see the good you do and give glory to your Father in heaven.	¹³ Y'all are the salt of the land. But if the salt loses flavor/is foolish, with what can it be made salty again? It's useful for nothing, except to be thrown out and stepped on by people. ¹⁴ Y'all are the light of the world. It is not able to be hidden, a city that is set up on a mountain, ¹⁵ and they don't light a candle and place it under a basket. Rather, upon a candle-stand, and it will shine on everyone in the house. ¹⁶ In the same way, let your light shine before people, so that they can see your good works, and so they can give honor to your Father who is in the skies.	¹³ You are the salt of the earth. But if the salt has lost its taste, how will it recover its salt? Its powers are for nothing except to be thrown away And trampled underfoot by others. ¹⁴ You are the light of the world. A city cannot be hidden when it is set on a mountain. ¹⁵ Nor do they light a lamp and place it under a basket, But on a stand, And it glows on everyone in the house. ¹⁶ So let your light glow before people so they may see Your good works and glorify your father of the skies.

COMMENTARY QUOTES

The address is in the second-person plural [you **all**] not only because more than one person is being addressed, but because it is the corporate impact of the disciple community, as an alternative society, which is here in view. The hilltop town of v.14 is a symbol not of a conspicuous individual but of the collective impact of a whole community. Modern Western individualism is such that we easily think of the light of the world as a variety of little candles shining, "you in your small corner, and I in mine," but it is **the collective light of a whole community which draws the attention of the watching world.**

—R.T. France, *The Gospel of Matthew*, p.171

Putting [salt, light, city] into the context of Isaiah, a vision emerges that makes an important salvation-historical and theological point: **Both the salt and light metaphors are communicating the same idea, that Jesus's disciples are now the heralds of the new and lasting covenant being effected by Jesus.**

—Jonathan Pennington, *The Sermon on the Mount and Human Flourishing*, p.164

OLD TESTAMENT Isaiah 60:1–3, 14 (NASB)

[Relevance: The promise of Israel’s eventual covenant, renewal, and glory are probably in the minds of Jesus’s audience when he is talking about salt, city, and light.]

“Arise, shine; for your light has come,
And the glory of the Lord has risen upon you.
For behold, darkness will cover the earth
And deep darkness the peoples;
But the Lord will rise upon you
And His glory will appear upon you.
Nations will come to your light,
And kings to the brightness of your rising.
...
The sons of those who afflicted you will come bowing to you,
And all those who despised you will bow down at the soles of your feet;
And they will call you the city of the Lord,
The Zion of the Holy One of Israel.

CHALLENGING QUESTIONS

1. Since both salt and light can be used metaphorically a number of ways, what was the intention (or intentions) of Jesus when he used them?
2. Are Jesus’s followers the light of the world? Is Jesus the light of the world (Jn 8:12)? Both? (and if so, how does that work?)
3. What does it mean, after decoding the metaphor, for salt to lose its saltiness? Can a Christian lose their “Christian-ness”, or is the absurdity of it the whole point?

JOURNAL NOTES	
¹³ You are the salt of the earth, but if salt has lost its taste, how shall its saltiness be restored? It is no longer good for anything except to be thrown out and trampled under people’s feet. ¹⁴ You are the light of the world. A city set on a hill cannot be hidden. ¹⁵ Nor do people light a lamp and put it under a basket, but on a stand, and it gives light to all in the house. ¹⁶ In the same way, let your light shine before others, so that they may see your good works and give glory to your Father who is in heaven. (ESV)	